

SENATE No. 119

The Commonwealth of Massachusetts

PRESENTED BY:

Sal N. DiDomenico

To the Honorable Senate and House of Representatives of the Commonwealth of Massachusetts in General Court assembled:

The undersigned legislators and/or citizens respectfully petition for the adoption of the accompanying bill:

An Act establishing a loan repayment program for human services workers.

PETITION OF:

NAME:	DISTRICT/ADDRESS:	
<i>Sal N. DiDomenico</i>	<i>Middlesex and Suffolk</i>	
<i>Joanne M. Comerford</i>	<i>Hampshire, Franklin and Worcester</i>	<i>2/4/2025</i>
<i>James K. Hawkins</i>	<i>2nd Bristol</i>	<i>2/12/2025</i>
<i>Kathleen R. LaNatra</i>	<i>12th Plymouth</i>	<i>2/18/2025</i>
<i>John F. Keenan</i>	<i>Norfolk and Plymouth</i>	<i>2/21/2025</i>
<i>Patrick M. O'Connor</i>	<i>First Plymouth and Norfolk</i>	<i>2/21/2025</i>
<i>Manny Cruz</i>	<i>7th Essex</i>	<i>3/3/2025</i>
<i>Bruce E. Tarr</i>	<i>First Essex and Middlesex</i>	<i>3/3/2025</i>
<i>Michael D. Brady</i>	<i>Second Plymouth and Norfolk</i>	<i>3/3/2025</i>
<i>Brendan P. Crighton</i>	<i>Third Essex</i>	<i>3/3/2025</i>
<i>James B. Eldridge</i>	<i>Middlesex and Worcester</i>	<i>3/3/2025</i>
<i>Dylan A. Fernandes</i>	<i>Plymouth and Barnstable</i>	<i>3/12/2025</i>
<i>Robyn K. Kennedy</i>	<i>First Worcester</i>	<i>3/12/2025</i>
<i>Liz Miranda</i>	<i>Second Suffolk</i>	<i>3/19/2025</i>
<i>Mike Connolly</i>	<i>26th Middlesex</i>	<i>4/8/2025</i>
<i>William J. Driscoll, Jr.</i>	<i>Norfolk, Plymouth and Bristol</i>	<i>6/4/2025</i>
<i>Pavel M. Payano</i>	<i>First Essex</i>	<i>6/10/2025</i>

SENATE No. 119

By Mr. DiDomenico, a petition (accompanied by bill, Senate, No. 119) of Sal N. DiDomenico, Joanne M. Comerford, James K. Hawkins, Kathleen R. LaNatra and other members of the General Court for legislation relative to a loan repayment program for human services workers. Children, Families and Persons with Disabilities.

[SIMILAR MATTER FILED IN PREVIOUS SESSION
SEE SENATE, NO. 77 OF 2023-2024.]

The Commonwealth of Massachusetts

In the One Hundred and Ninety-Fourth General Court
(2025-2026)

An Act establishing a loan repayment program for human services workers.

Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives in General Court assembled, and by the authority of the same, as follows:

1 Chapter 6A of the General Laws, as so appearing in the 2022 Official Edition, is hereby
2 amended by inserting after section 16Z the following new section:-

3 Section 16AA. (a) As used in this section, the following words shall, unless the context
4 clearly requires otherwise, have the following meanings:

5 “Advancing Health Equity in Massachusetts (AHM)” priority geographic areas include
6 communities facing the largest health disparities, as identified by the Executive Office of Health
7 and Human Services. AHM communities include Athol, Attleboro, Aye, Brockton, Chelsea,
8 Chicopee, Dennis, Dorchester, Fall River, Falmouth, Fitchburg, Gardner, Holbrook, Holyoke,
9 Lawrence, Lowell, Lynn, Mattapan, New Bedford, North Adams, Orange, Pittsfield, Rockland,

Roxbury, Springfield, Southbridge, Ware, Wareham, Webster, Winchendon, Worcester, and Yarmouth.

“human service provider,” a community-based human services organization with a human services program funded by the Executive Office of Health and Human Services, the Executive Office of Elder Affairs, the Executive Office of Housing and Livable Communities or the Department of Early Education and Care.

“human services worker,” an employee of a human service provider who provides treatment, support or services to clients or their families.

“qualified education loan,” any indebtedness, including interest on such indebtedness, incurred to pay tuition or other direct expenses incurred in the connection with the pursuit of a certificate, undergraduate or graduate degree by an applicant. It shall not include loans made by any person related to the applicant.

(b) There shall be a student loan repayment program for human service workers to encourage individuals to enter the field and maintain employment at human service programs. The Executive Office of Health and Human Services shall administer the program in accordance with guidelines promulgated by the Department of Higher Education.

(c) To be eligible for the program, a participant must be working a minimum of 35 hours per week as a human services worker. Further, individuals must have maintained 12 consecutive months of employment as a human service worker at a minimum of 35 hours per week to be eligible for this program. This program will help defray costs from previously incurred student loans for graduates holding a certificate or undergraduate/graduate degrees.

(d) Eligibility criteria may be created to determine how applicants to the program should be prioritized and how much funding each would be able to apply for.

(e) Priority for funding should be given to applicants who 1) have at least three years of experience in the human services field, 2) work in an Advancing Health Equity in Massachusetts (AHEM) community, 3) earn less than \$60,000 annually, and 4) attest to their ability to communicate with consumers and provide care in a language other than English, with the language skill aligning with the needs of the site where they work.

(f) Applicants will be eligible for up to \$6,000 if they have an associate degree, up to \$20,000 if they have a bachelor's degree and up to \$30,000 if they have a master's degree.

(g) Applicants must agree to service commitment in an eligible setting as follows: 1-year commitment for an associate degree, 2-year commitment for a bachelor's degree and 3-year commitment for a master's degree.